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THERE IS A new trend in the Indian fashion industry, and it has little to do with fabric, embroidery or bling. Instead, it is of corporate houses, primarily Aditya Birla Fashion and Retail Ltd (ABFRL) and Reliance Brands Ltd (RBL), betting big on Indian designers. Earlier this year, RBL bought a 51 per cent majority stake in couture brand Abu Jani Sandeep Khosla and all its supplementary offerings, including GULABO by Abu Sandeep, ASAL by Abu Sandeep and MARD by Abu Sandeep. Jani and Khosla are the newest additions to an impressive line-up for Reliance that features strategic partnerships with designers Satya Paul, Raghavendra Rathore, Ritu Kumar, Anamika Khanna, Manish Malhotra, Rahul Mishra and Abraham & Thakore. Six of these partnerships took place in the past one year. RBL acquired Satya Paul in 2018 and its first strategic partnership was with Raghavendra Rathore in 2019.

But the trend was started by ABFRL—part of the Aditya Birla Group, which had revenues of ₹2,875 crore in the quarter ended June 30—when in 2019 it acquired a 51 per cent stake in designers Shantanu & Nikhil's company Finesse International Design Pvt. Ltd. It followed up with a 51 per cent stake in designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee's fashion house in January last year. With designer Tarun Tahiliani, it established a new company in February of last year and launched a contemporary men's ethnic wear brand called Tasva, with the goal of selling ₹500 crore worth of men's ethnic clothes and accessories in five years. ABFRL owns an 80 per cent stake in the new entity and Tarun Tahiliani holds the balance. It also bought a 33.5



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“Access to capital and the ability to take decisions that give long-term benefits are key advantages. Plus, RRVL has a lot of brands, so dovetailing with what it is doing, we get better rates and better access”

Amrish Kumar
MANAGING DIRECTOR,
RELIANCE RITU KUMAR